The second tipping point was the news in January 1960 that Beijing had struck a deal with Rangoon on the China–Burma border dispute. In the deal, China had recognized a section of the McMahon Line. Burma had accepted in return that the border was not delimited.[30] Nehru had just come round to inviting Zhou to visit Delhi once again – not for thoroughgoing 'negotiations' on the border but rather for 'talks' to help ease military tensions.[31] Delhi expected to be offered a swap deal involving recognition of Chinese claims in the western sector in return for the status quo in the eastern sector. In light of Gopal's evidence and other briefings, as also the growing anger in India on China policy, the Indians decided they would reject the Chinese offer. In a private meeting, Nehru declared, 'If I give them that [the swap] I shall no longer be Prime Minister of India – I will not do it.'[32]

The third tipping point was the summit meeting itself, which turned out to be a diplomatic disaster. Nehru and Zhou talked one-on-one for twenty hours over seven meetings. In addition, Zhou met other Indian leaders. At the end of it, though, both sides had restated well-worn positions, without any breakthroughs. As for the swap, it is unclear how categorically the Chinese made the offer, but at the very least Zhou signalled that the swap was a possible solution – or part of a solution. However, except perhaps for Vice President Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan (incidentally, Gopal's father), no one of standing in India supported a swap.[33]

Why did India reject the swap, which seems such an obvious way to settle the conflict? The record suggests that the Indian side was unsure whether the offer was formal and unequivocal: in Delhi's view, Zhou had changed tack several times on the McMahon Line going back to 1954 and had provided nothing in writing anyway. Also, a swap meant India would relinquish its western claims altogether and in return get to keep its eastern claims. China would therefore come out better. Its forces would advance in the western sector while India's forces would remain where they were in the eastern sector. Beyond this worry was the fear that the swap might be the slippery slope to yet more swaps, leading to further loss of territory all along the border. If India agreed to a swap after a series of military clashes